

A COMMUNITY TALK

The Attention Economy

The science of screen time — and how to take it back.

Presented by [Your Name]

Founder, Drift · [Library Name] · [Date]



THE HABIT WE BARELY NOTICE

When did you last check your phone?

The average person now checks **205 times a day** — about once every five waking minutes. Ask people to guess their own number, and most say ten.

THE SCALE OF IT

This is the average — not the extreme

4h 39m

Average time an adult spends on their phone every day (2024)

205×

Times a day we check it — about once every 5 waking minutes

2,617

Separate taps, swipes and clicks on it every single day

*That's more than **70 full days a year** — over two months of your waking life, every single year, spent looking at a screen.*



YOUR TURN
**Scan to see
your own
number**

A 20-second calculator:
how many years of your life
your phone adds up to.

PART 1

Why it's so hard to put down

Four forces engineered into the apps in your pocket — none of them
about your character.



THE MYTH

It is not a willpower problem

We treat phone habits like a moral failing — just put it down, show some discipline.

But you are not facing a neutral tool. You're facing thousands of the world's best designers, data scientists and behavioral psychologists — whose full-time job is to keep your attention.

THE ASYMMETRY

You

A few minutes of willpower, at the end of a tired day.

vs.

A billion-dollar industry

Optimizing every pixel, 24/7, with your data as feedback.

A slot machine in your pocket

Variable-ratio reinforcement. B.F. Skinner found that rewards delivered on an unpredictable schedule are the most compulsive of all — more than a predictable reward every time.

Pull to refresh. Maybe something great, maybe nothing. That "maybe" is the exact mechanism slot machines use — now on the screen you check 205 times a day.

1 Pull to refresh
the lever

2 Unpredictable payoff
the jackpot

3 Do it again
the compulsion

Dopamine isn't the pleasure chemical

THE MYTH

"Dopamine = pleasure. Likes make us feel good."

If it were really pleasure, we'd feel satisfied and stop. We don't.

WHAT THE RESEARCH SHOWS

Dopamine drives wanting — not liking.

Berridge & Robinson's work separates **seeking** from **enjoying**. Apps flood the 'seeking' system — so you keep chasing a hit you never quite land. That's the itch you can't scratch.

Designed to have no natural stopping point

1 Infinite scroll

The page never ends. Older designs had page 2, page 3 — a natural 'shall I go on?' moment. That pause was deliberately removed.

2 Autoplay

The next video starts before you decide to watch it. The default is 'keep going,' and defaults win.

3 Streaks & badges

Manufactured obligations that punish you for stopping — quit and you 'lose' something.

The old way had stopping cues

An empty plate. The end of a chapter. The last page of the newspaper. A signal that said: you're done.

The feed removed all of them.

Every glance costs more than the glance

Attention residue. Every time you switch — even a five-second glance at a notification — part of your mind stays stuck on the last thing. Sophie Leroy named this in 2009: your full attention doesn't arrive with you.

So a five-second check doesn't cost five seconds. UC Irvine's Gloria Mark clocked the average return to full focus at **23 minutes**. Her latest work: our attention on any one screen now lasts about **47 seconds**.

5 sec

The glance you notice

23 min

To refocus fully after a single interruption

THE BODY KEEPS THE SCORE

It follows you into the night

Blue light delays sleep

In a Harvard study (PNAS, 2015), reading on a screen before bed cut melatonin by **50%+** and pushed the body clock back ~**1.5 hours** — with groggier mornings after.

The bedtime doomscroll

The variable-reward loop is most powerful when you're tired and your guard is down — exactly when you meant to sleep.

Displacement

Every hour on the phone is an hour not spent sleeping, moving, or with people. Often it's the sleep and face-to-face time that lose.

THE GENERATION THAT GREW UP ON IT

The timing is hard to ignore

Teen mental health held broadly steady through the 2000s — then turned sharply downward around **2012–2013**, just as smartphones and social media became near-universal. The rise in anxiety, depression and self-harm was steepest among **teen girls**.

Psychologist **Jonathan Haidt** (*The Anxious Generation*, 2024) calls it a "great rewiring of childhood." The science is still **correlational and debated** — but few dispute the pattern.

~2012

When the curves for teen depression and self-harm began to climb

~20 hrs

A week the average teen girl now spends on social media

PART 2

The reframe that changes everything

Stop fighting yourself. Start changing the design around you.



The problem was never your ~~willpower~~. The problem is the **design**.

WHAT FOLLOWS FROM THAT



Willpower doesn't scale

You can't out-discipline a system optimizing against you 24/7. It works a day and fails on the tired ones.



Design does scale

Change your environment once and it keeps working while you sleep — no daily heroics required.



This is good news

The fix isn't 'become a better person.' It's 'set things up smarter.' That's learnable.

PART 3

What actually works

Five design principles you can use tonight — no app required.



Five principles that beat willpower

1 Add friction

Make the pull-to-open cost a few seconds more.

2 Design your environment

Change defaults so the easy path is the good one.

3 Use a commitment device

Lock in your future self while you're clear-headed.

4 Replace, don't just remove

Give the freed-up time somewhere to go.

5 Make it accountable

Borrow social pressure — do it with others.

None of these require more discipline. They require better setup — done once.

PRINCIPLE 1

Add friction to the bad, remove it from the good

Small speed bumps beat big intentions. A 15-second delay is often enough to break the automatic reach.

Grayscale mode

Draining the color makes the feed far less magnetic — the dopamine cues dim.

Delete, don't just close

Kill the app; use it in the browser. The extra step is the point.

Log out every time

Re-typing the password is a 15-second pause that lets the urge pass.

Hide the triggers

Off the home screen, into a folder on page 3. Out of sight, out of thumb.

Kill the badges

Turn off red notification dots — they manufacture urgency that isn't real.

Charge it in another room

Friction for the worst offender: the bedtime and first-thing scroll.

PRINCIPLE 2

Design defaults, because defaults win

You will not make a fresh, wise decision 96 times a day. So don't rely on deciding — set the default once, and let it carry you.



Phone-free zones

The dinner table. The bedroom. The first 30 minutes awake. Make the rule about the place, not the moment.



A basket by the door

A home for the phone when you walk in, so it isn't fused to your hand all evening.



Analog alarm clock

Breaks the most damaging loop: phone last thing at night, first in the morning.



Scheduled downtime

Use the phone's own tools to auto-lock distracting apps at set hours — a default you don't renegotiate.

PRINCIPLE 3

Commitment devices: bind your future self

A choice you make now, while you're clear-headed, that limits what tired-you can do later.

Odysseus tying himself to the mast so he couldn't chase the sirens — same idea, modern problem.

App limits with teeth

Set a hard cap you can't casually override in the moment of weakness.

Stakes & promises

Tell someone your goal, or put money on it. Now quitting has a cost.

Earn-it systems

Make screen time contingent on something first — a walk, a task, real life.

PRINCIPLE 4

Replace the habit — don't just delete it

A phone habit fills a real need — boredom, stress, connection, a moment's rest. Remove it without a replacement and the vacuum pulls you right back.

Bored in a queue → A book or podcast queued and ready

Winding down at night → A bath, a stretch, a few pages of fiction

Craving connection → A text to a real friend, or a call

Need a mental break → A walk outside — five minutes resets more than a scroll

PRINCIPLE 5

Do it with other people

Willpower is a solo sport and it loses. Accountability borrows other people's — and turns a private struggle into a shared one.



Phone stacks

At dinner, everyone's phone goes in a pile. First to reach for it does the dishes.



A screen-time buddy

Share weekly numbers with a friend. Being seen changes behavior more than any setting.



Family charging station

One spot where everyone's phone sleeps at night. The rule applies to parents too.



Tell people your why

Saying the goal out loud makes backing out cost something social.

SO FAR

What we've covered

The science

It's not willpower. Reward loops, dopamine-seeking, no stopping cues and attention residue are engineered in.

The reframe

Stop fighting yourself. Change the design around you — that's what scales.

✓ **Add friction** — slow the bad, speed the good.

✓ **Design defaults** — decide once; let it carry you.

✓ **Commit ahead** — bind your future self.

✓ **Replace & share** — fill the gap; do it with others.

PART 4

One tool that does this for you

Full disclosure: this is the part I built. Everything before it stands on its own.



WHY I BUILT DRIFT

I couldn't out-willpower my own phone either.

I tried every tip on the last few slides. They worked — until a tired evening, when I'd just turn the limit off.

So I built the commitment device I wished existed: one that makes the good thing the price of the screen time. Not more discipline — better design, running for me.



HOW DRIFT WORKS

Earn your screen time

1

Choose what to block

Pick the apps that eat your day. Drift puts a Screen Time shield in front of them.



2

Do something real first

Complete a task, a walk, a goal — the things you actually want to spend time on.



3

Unlock earned time

Real effort converts into minutes. The shield lifts for exactly what you've earned — then it's back.

The flip: screens stop being the default you fall into, and become the reward you unlock — after real life gets its turn first.

WHY IT WORKS

Drift is tonight's science, automated



Adds friction

The shield is a real speed bump in front of the apps you chose — not a reminder you can wave away.



It's a commitment device

You set the rules clear-headed; tired-you can't casually override them at 11pm.



Earn-it, built in

Screen time becomes contingent on real effort — Principle 3, running automatically.



Replaces, doesn't just block

The 'task first' step points you at the better thing, so blocking doesn't leave a vacuum.

You don't have to remember to do all five by hand. That's the only thing the app really sells: it makes the good design the default, so you don't have to.

TRY IT TONIGHT

Start with one small thing

1 Pick one tip

Grayscale, or charge your phone outside the bedroom.

2 Try Drift free

Set up your first shield and earn time in two minutes.

3 Keep the calculator

Revisit your number anytime, and pass it to a friend.

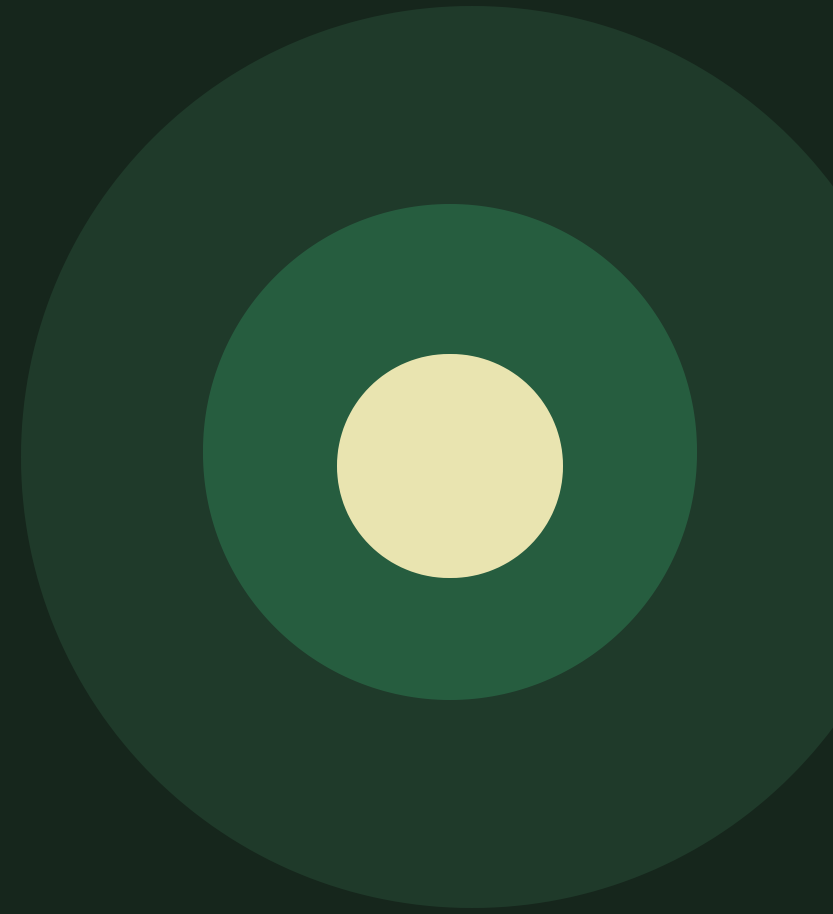


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OVER TO YOU

Questions?

*If one idea tonight earns back even an hour of your week,
that's a win.*



SOURCES & FURTHER READING

Go deeper

eMarketer / Data.ai (2024)

US adults average ~4h 39m of daily phone use.

dscout (2016)

2,617 daily touches; 5,427 for heavy users.

Berridge & Robinson (2016)

Dopamine as 'wanting,' not 'liking.'

Chang et al., PNAS (2015)

Evening screen light suppresses melatonin, delays sleep.

Reviews.org (2024)

Americans check their phones 205× a day, up from 144.

Skinner · Harris / CHT

Variable-ratio rewards & persuasive design.

Leroy (2009) · Mark, UC Irvine

Attention residue; 23-min refocus; 47-sec spans.

Haidt (2024)

The Anxious Generation — youth & screens (debated).

Read further

Stolen Focus (Hari) · *Indistractable* (Eyal) · *Atomic Habits* (Clear) · *Digital Minimalism* (Newport).

Thank you. — [Your Name], Drift · [email / getdriftapp.org]